

THE BOOK OF YOU

Wren

Chapter 10

October 2026

“Hour and Weather”

19 days bound · 39 kept pages

bound in the lamplight style

Made with ReEnchanted · reenchanted.app

Foreword

October 2026, bound: 39 pages across 19 days. None of it arrived here by accident: you chose every one.

A month that isn't written down doesn't politely wait to be remembered. It goes. That's the entire reason for the thread and the glue.

Reading it back, I found something you were not in a position to see. You kept saying “work”. 4 times, across 4 of your 17 written days. You may not have repeated it on purpose. A word returning this often earns a ribbon; I’m not deciding why.

I've read every page of this twice. Once as it arrived, once just now.

The Book





The Month's Theme

Hour and Weather

The pages kept returning to Hour, Weather, and Clear, the way a reader rereads a favorite paragraph without deciding to.

> *“Your Brother Laughed Twice You called your brother back instead of texting.”*

> *“Clear and sharp.”*

Hour Weather Clear

Contents

The Almanac

The month's moons, and the nights, scenes and photographs it kept.

The Labyrinth

Where everyone was, and where you were.

The Cast

Who was in the room.

The Days

Each date, the world's side and yours.

What This Month Was

The Month's Theme

One current I found running under the month, named and held up to the light.

What I Noticed

Connections, absences, durations, and living Beliefs gathered from the month.

What I Noticed

Connections that only show up when a whole month is held still at once.

Book Memory Spine

The nightly Book of You pages, read as callbacks, refrains, and open questions.

The Complete Archive

Everything else the month kept: weather, anchors, enchantments, classes, questions, and every other margin. Nothing here was left out.

October

2026

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
				1	2	3
4	5	6	7	8	9	10
11	12	13	14	15	16	17
18	19	20	21	22	23	24
25	26	27	28	29	30	31

● *a night braided* ○ *a scene read* ▪ *a photograph kept*

9 NIGHTS BRAIDED · 22 SCENES READ · 2 PHOTOGRAPHS KEPT

THE SKY'S FAVORITE TRICKS

I caught the outer weather on 17 days: clear on 8 days, wind on 7 days, cloud on 5 days, and rain on 4 days. Blank sky-days stayed blank; I did not dress them up from memory.

WHEN THE INK CAME IN

The kept Pages with a clock-mark arrived morning on 17 days, afternoon on 10 days, night on 9 days, and evening on 6 days. This is the ink's timetable, not yours; a life keeps plenty I never see.

THE WEEKS

Week 1 · Oct 2 – Oct 7

Strongest night: The Cold Lake

Week 2 · Oct 8 – Oct 13

Week 3 · Oct 15 – Oct 19

Strongest night: The Card in the Atlas

Week 4 · Oct 22 – Oct 28

Strongest night: Bread That Would Not Rise

Week 5 · Oct 29 – Oct 30

Strongest night: Nine Books, No Plan

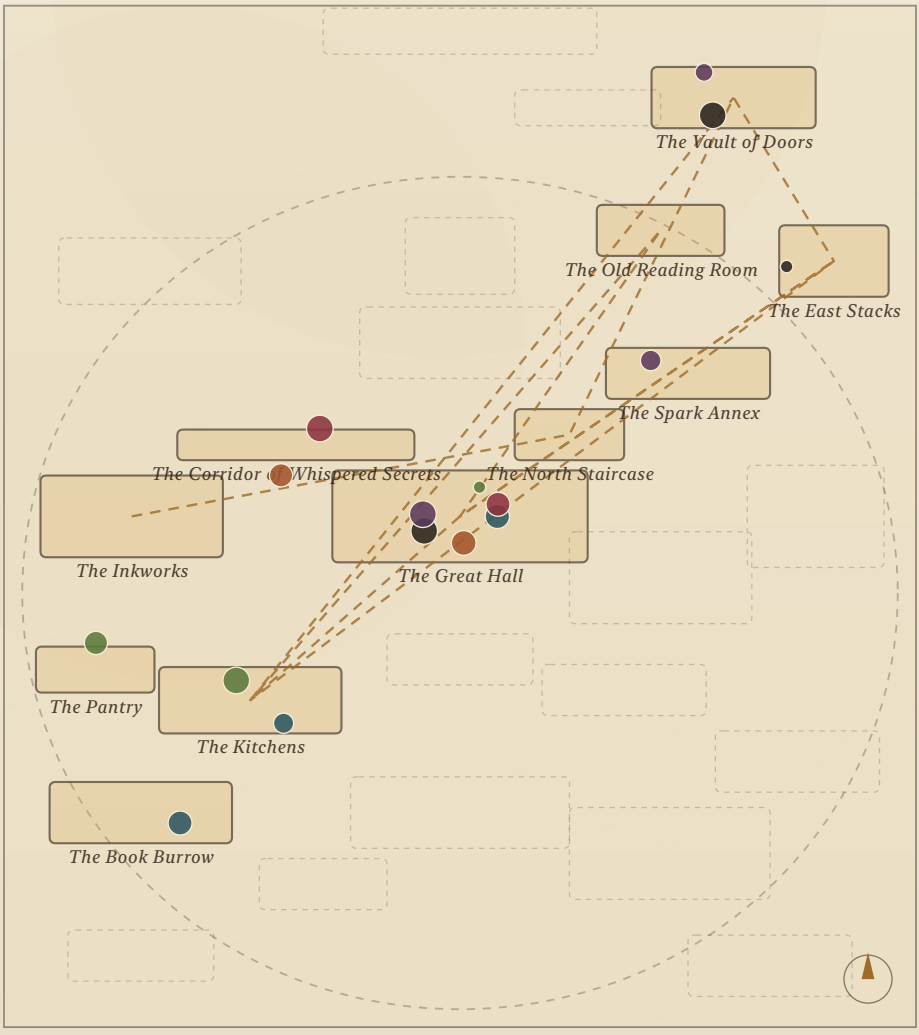
THE STORY, IN THE ORDER YOU MET IT

Oct 2 · A sentence with its coat off
Oct 3 · The wrong way to the classroom
Oct 4 · Sunday Book Jump Club
Oct 4 · One verb
Oct 4 · Every named traveller
Oct 8 · The East Stacks Incident
Oct 10 · The map with room left
Oct 15 · The Man Reading Himself
Oct 18 · Which preparation?
Oct 18 · Supper with a Finished Man
Oct 22 · The Wrong Castle
Oct 28 · A Future Tense
Oct 28 · Return by Terms
Oct 28 · The claim is hers
Oct 29 · The First Nightbound Morning
Oct 30 · Threshold Protocols



Where everyone was

Drawn from the scenes you read and the Academy's timetable. A room stays blank until the story has been there.



- Serenity Brown · 21 scenes
- Professor Permancer · 16 scenes
- Ambrose Trencher · 8 scenes
- Penny Blackletter · 19 scenes
- Wicker Eddies · 16 scenes
- Soren Ng · 3 scenes

Room by room

Serenity Brown
The Great Hall · The Book Burrow · The Kitchens · The Quillquarium

Penny Blackletter
The Stacks · The Great Hall · The Corridor of Whispered Secrets · The East Stacks

Professor Permancer
The Vault of Doors · The Great Hall · The East Stacks · The Kitchens

Wicker Eddies
The Great Hall · The Spark Annex · The Vault of Doors · The East Stacks

Ambrose Trencher
The Kitchens · The Pantry · The Great Hall

Soren Ng
The Corridor of Whispered Secrets · The Great Hall · The Stacks · The Book Burrow





Serenity Brown

in 21 scenes you read · most often in The Great Hall and The Book Burrow



Penny Blackletter

in 19 scenes you read · most often in The Stacks and The Great Hall



Professor Permancer

in 16 scenes you read · most often in The Vault of Doors and The Great Hall



Wicker Eddies

in 16 scenes you read · most often in The Great Hall and The Spark Annex

WEEK 1

Oct 2 – Oct 7

FRI SAT SUN MON TUE WED THU

THE WEEK'S STRONGEST NIGHT

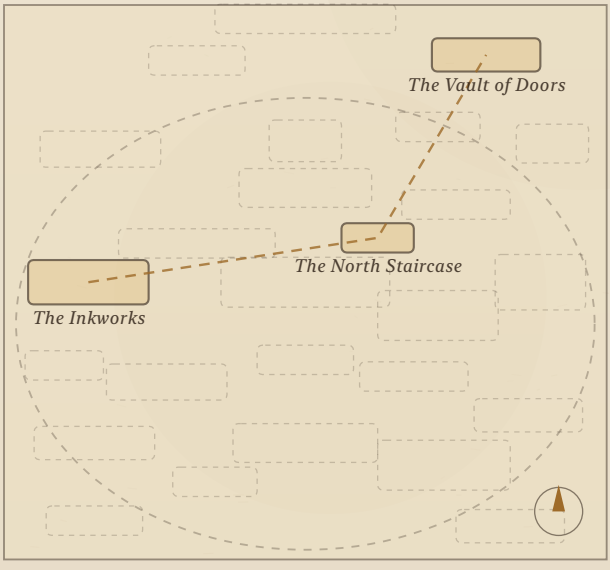
The Cold Lake

THE WEEK, DAY BY DAY

FRI 2	A sentence with its coat off
SAT 3	The wrong way to the classroom
SUN 4	Sunday Book Jump Club
TUE 6	The Cold Lake
WED 7	kept 1 small thing

1 NIGHT BRAIDED

WHERE IT HAPPENED



2

FRIDAY · OCTOBER 2026

◐ Last Quarter

IN THE ROOM


PROFESSOR


PENNY


SERENITY


WICKER

IN THE LABYRINTH · WING 1: THE INKWORKS

A sentence with its coat off

Professor Villanelle has written a sentence on the board.

> *The ineffable splendour of dawn bestowed a profound sense of possibility upon the weary traveller.*

Something behind the plaster coughs.

Villanelle waits until we've all read it.

“What happened?”

Penny Blackletter raises her hand.

“Someone got up.”

“Where?”

“The sentence hasn't said.”

“What did they see?”

Penny looks at the board again. “It hasn't said that either.”

Villanelle rubs out *ineffable*. The chalk squeals. She keeps rubbing.

“I was at the bus stop,” she says. “I had a headache. Someone had left an orange on the bench.”

She wipes the rest away.

There was an orange on the wet bench, bright enough that I nearly missed the bus.

The thing in the wall stops coughing.

I like the orange. I can get my teeth round it.

Serenity has been working on a sentence of her own. Wicker bends sideways to read it.

She puts her hand over the page.

“Ask.”

“Is it about me?”

“It was about something that needed throwing out. I can see why you're hopeful.”

Villanelle reaches between them and takes Wicker's unused paper.

“Your turn.”

He looks at the blank. For once, it gets the first word.

Library kept returning through the kept pages.



3

SATURDAY · OCTOBER 2026

◐ Last Quarter

IN THE ROOM



SERENITY



SOREN

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE NORTH STAIRCASE

The wrong way to the classroom

you chose · "Show us the glass roof."

Serenity has lost the classroom.

She knows where it was. She drew a good map yesterday. The corridor has taken this personally.

"We could ask," I say.

"We're almost there."

We've passed the same boot three times. It's growing confident.

On the next windowsill sits a paper bird. One wing points left. Written under it are the words *if you want the room.* On the other wing: *if you want the long way.*

Serenity turns it over. There's a tiny drawing of her boat underneath.

"Soren."

She sounds pleased. Then she frowns at the two wings.

"He could've waited for us."

Soren Ng is sitting on the stair beyond the left-hand door. He has two chalk stubs and an expression that was clearly meant to look accidental.

“The long way has a glass roof,” he says.

“You put my boat on a bird.”

“It needed to get upstairs.”

She sits beside him to examine the fold. He shows her where the paper turns. Their hands meet at the wing; he lets her finish it.

Wicker comes through the classroom door behind them.

“How elaborate. Have you tried saying hello?”

“Hello, Wicker,” Soren says.

Serenity laughs into the bird.

The wrong way to the classroom

I nip the tail of the paper bird when nobody's looking. It nips my ribbon back.

Rain kept returning through the kept pages.



4

SUNDAY · OCTOBER 2026

◐ Last Quarter

IN THE ROOM


PROFESSOR


WICKER


PENNY


SERENITY

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE VAULT OF DOORS

Sunday Book Jump Club

you chose · Enter the supervised Jump

Professor Permancer lays a ribbon across the floor.

"That end stays here."

The ribbon immediately crawls towards his shoe.

"Approximately here."

He kneels, makes a loop, and passes the end through it. He does it again slowly. Penny copies him. Wicker produces a knot that has trapped his thumb.

Permancer frees it without comment.

For this first visit, I'm keeping hold of the ribbon. You don't owe me a sentence to find the way home.

Permancer touches the ribbon. A little door opens above the knot. Through it I can see his office, including a cup he has been searching for since breakfast.

He puts his hand through, retrieves it, and comes back.

"Now," he says. "Where was my way home?"

Everyone points at the ribbon.

"Good. Keep looking at it when there's something more interesting to look at."

Sunday Book Jump Club

you chose · The knot.

The Vault has polished its handles for Sunday. Even the dangerous ones are keeping still.

Penny checks the list beside the open copy of *Dracula*.

“Permancer. Wicker. You. Me.”

“Still no Dracula?” Wicker asks.

“He lives there.”

“Then he can make the tea.”

“We don't accept food,” Permancer says. “Or shelter. We follow the entrance hall to the first landing. Then we return.”

Ribbons run from his bookmark to each name on Penny's list. I have yours. Don't pull; I'm holding something at the other end.

One verb

you chose · Tell Wicker to cross it out.

Permancer steps through. Penny follows. The ribbon draws you into the crease.

Words race beneath your shoes. Then stone catches your feet.

The table is longer than it looked. An orange sits at the far end under an unlit chandelier.

I put a corner out to see it better. Penny catches me.

“Observe,” she whispers.

I was observing with my mouth.

A door opens. Dracula comes in.

“You have come a long way.”

He stops beside the table. One hand rests on the chair. A paragraph

holds him there.

Wicker moves sideways. Dracula's eyes don't follow.

“He can't see us properly.”

“He's held at this passage,” Permancer says. “It lets the lesson enter without changing his next action.”

“You've pinned him.”

“Wicker. Put the pen away.”

But the pen is already down in the gutter. Wicker writes:

For one sentence, let him choose the verb.

The table draws in its legs. The orange rolls.

Dracula looks at Wicker. Then at you. Then at the light behind you.

“What follows?” he asks.

Every named traveller

The chandelier burns black.

“Penny, through. You next.”

I pull the ribbon towards the Vault. A word catches in my stitching. I leave it there. I need both covers for this.

Penny reaches the light. You follow.

Wicker backs towards the doorway.

“I gave you one verb.”

Dracula smiles.

“Follow.”

Wicker crosses. Permancer holds the way open behind him.

“Back through. All of you.”

The words reach farther than the ribbon.

Then the professor is home. The source slams shut.

Penny runs her finger down the list. Every ribbon answers. Every

named traveller is back.

“Complete.”

Wicker sits on the floor. There's ink on his knee.

At supper he asks where Serenity is.

“Finishing her map,” Ambrose says. “The East Stacks.”

Wicker takes the bowl Ambrose gives him. It goes cold in his hands.

I go back through my stitching for the word I caught on the way home.

The word has gone.

Cloud kept returning through the kept pages.



NIGHT BRAID · KEPT AT 10:00 P.M.

The Cold Lake

You swam in the lake and the water was so cold it made you shout. You shouted anyway and kept swimming out to the yellow buoy and back.

I do not swim. I would go soggy. But I heard the shout from the towel on the bank, and it was the most awake sound you have made all summer. The Curse is afraid of cold water. I think I understand why.

The Book kept the page: the lake was cold, and you shouted and swam anyway.

SPECIMENS COLLECTED

Ink for Today 9:00

your own words

Tidied the shelf of things I never use at Amanda's. I kept thinking about it on the bus.



WEEK 2

Oct 8 – Oct 13

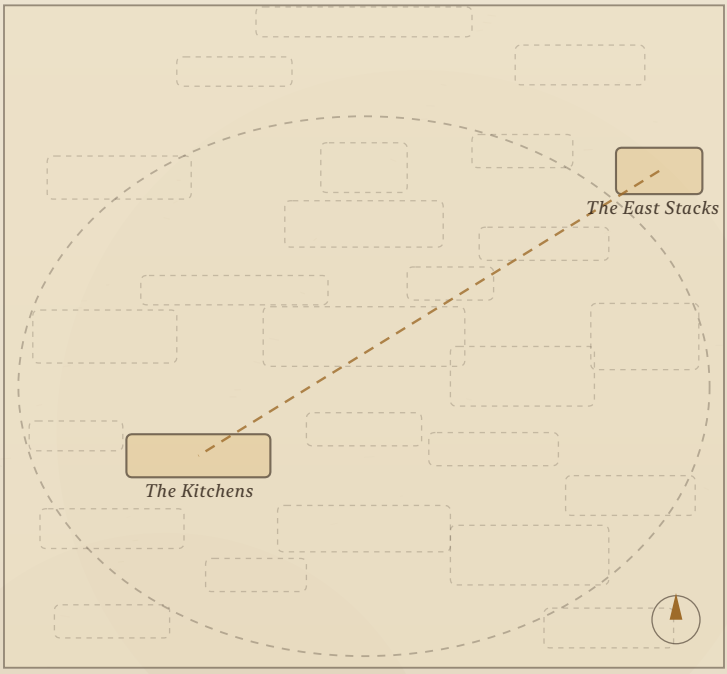
THU FRI SAT SUN MON TUE WED

THE WEEK, DAY BY DAY

THU 8	The East Stacks Incident
FRI 9	kept 2 small things
SAT 10	The map with room left
SUN 11	kept 2 small things
TUE 13	kept 1 small thing

0 NIGHTS BRAIDED

WHERE IT HAPPENED



8

THURSDAY · OCTOBER 2026

Waning Crescent

IN THE ROOM


SERENITY


WICKER


PENNY


PROFESSOR

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE EAST STACKS

The East Stacks Incident

you chose · Move her map nearer.

A book lands in Ambrose's soup.

He fishes it out by the spine. *Doors That Should Stay Metaphors.* It drips on his shoes.

Another book falls in the hall. Then another, farther away.

I don't like how they're falling. Books go over like that when somebody's been past them in a hurry.

Ambrose puts down the ladle.

The East Stacks have squeezed their aisles shut. Penny goes sideways between them, following a trail of catalogue cards.

Each says the same thing.

HE WAS HERE.

“Serenity?” she calls.

Ambrose reaches the gap first. He kneels between Travel and Unreliable Geography.

Serenity is against the bottom shelf. Her map lies open beside her. Two small wounds show at her neck.

I shut. I didn't decide to.

“She's breathing. Bring a clean cloth.”

Wicker turns so sharply he hits the shelf. He comes back with three cloths and an empty water jug. He looks at the jug. Goes again.

Permancer's bookmark pulls towards Serenity, then the wall.

“A living anchor.”

Penny catches his sleeve. “Explain.”

“A person from a story has used her to hold himself here.”

“I gave him—” Wicker begins.

“Water first,” Ambrose says.

Serenity opens her eyes.

“Will someone stop turning that page?”

The books are all closed.

She reaches across the floor.

The East Stacks Incident

“His fingers were coming apart,” she says. “I told him he shouldn't be here.”

She looks at the cloth in Ambrose's hand.

“He said he'd found a way to stay.”

Wicker sets the water down. A little spills. He wipes it with his sleeve before anyone can ask.

Serenity sees him.

“What did you write?”

He tells her. The exact sentence. I keep it too.

She shuts her eyes again.

Wicker reaches towards her hand, then puts his own flat on the floor.

“Get my map,” she says to Ambrose.

The Kitchens door appears at the end of the aisle. It has come a long

way and left its hinges behind.

Ambrose lifts her. She keeps the map.

A black line travels across its sea, through a mountain, and into the north margin.

Serenity turns her head.

“He's there.”

Permancer takes a step towards the wall.

“Tomorrow,” she says.

He stops.

“Yes. Tomorrow.”

Wicker holds the Kitchens door. Serenity goes through without looking at him.

He stays with the handle long after Ambrose has put her down.

You're still here. I checked twice.

I don't like this aisle now. I'm going to remember where it is, so we never come back to it by accident.



Hour again. The theme insists.

10

SATURDAY · OCTOBER 2026

New Moon · sky clear

IN THE ROOM


SOREN


SERENITY


WICKER


AMBROSE

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE KITCHENS

The map with room left

Soren brings a sheet of tracing paper to the Kitchens.

Serenity is making a tower out of toast crusts. It leans. She's named it after Permancer.

“I've copied the coast,” Soren says.

Her face closes a little.

“For the investigation?”

“For the boat.”

He puts the paper down. He's drawn her little boat in six impossible harbours. One is in a tree.

Serenity looks at them for a long time.

“It'll need a ladder.”

“I wasn't sure how tall.”

She takes his pencil.

I start to close. She puts one finger between my leaves.

“Stay. We need a cliff.”

So I stand on my fore-edge while she draws a ladder up me. It tickles.

At the doorway, Wicker arrives with a repaired map case under his arm.

He sees Soren's paper. He turns the case so the repair faces his coat.

Ambrose takes it from him.

“Tea?”

“No.”

“Then stop standing in the draught.”

Wicker takes a seat at the far end. For the whole of one cup of tea, he has nothing to say about Soren's harbours.

Rain kept returning through the kept pages.



WEEK 3

Oct 15 – Oct 19



THE WEEK'S STRONGEST NIGHT

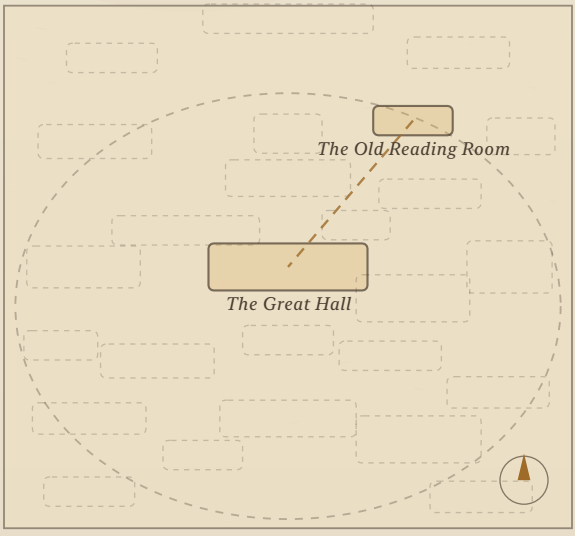
The Card in the Atlas

THE WEEK, DAY BY DAY

THU 15	The Man Reading Himself
FRI 16	The Card in the Atlas
SAT 17	What the Fox Knew
SUN 18	The Blue Door Changed Colour · Which preparation? · Supper with a Finished Man · a photograph
MON 19	kept 1 small thing

3 NIGHTS BRAIDED

WHERE IT HAPPENED



15

THURSDAY · OCTOBER 2026

Waxing Crescent · sky cloud, wind

Calvino's Birthday

IN THE ROOM


SERENITY


PENNY

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE OLD READING ROOM

The Man Reading Himself

you chose · "What would you do with a

"That one," Serenity says.

The old reading-room door stands open. Inside, Dracula sits under a green lamp, reading *Dracula*.

He has a pencil. I dislike this before he's done anything with it.

Beside a paragraph he's written:

He wouldn't have said this.

Penny leans round the door.

"You wrote that?"

"I was present."

"You can still be wrong."

Serenity steps into the light. Dracula rises.

"Miss Brown."

"Serenity."

He says it correctly. She waits.

Dracula puts his pencil down.

"I've read the last page."

His hand rests on the closed half of the book.

“Every morning returns me to a sentence I have already lived. You leave a room and something can happen to you. I leave mine because the next paragraph says I must.”

“So you hurt me,” Serenity says.

“I was disappearing.”

“You knew I was a person.”

He looks at her bandage.

“Yes.”

The Man Reading Himself

Dracula opens his book.

“I want a future tense. Yours has been waiting for you all day.”

“And if it costs someone else?” Penny asks.

“I intend to remain.”

Serenity stands. “Then we'd better learn how to send you back.”

His shadow moves first.

It touches the shelf. One book opens onto the sea. Another lets snow into the room. Roses push through a third and catch on Penny's sleeve.

Dracula steps backwards between them.

For a moment he stands in three different doorways.

Then the books close.

Serenity unfolds her map. The black line has split into branches.

Penny pulls a rose thorn from her cuff.

“How many ways?”

“More than yesterday.”

I keep the fallen thorn. It came out of a book and it can still scratch you.

NIGHT BRAID · KEPT AT 10:00 P.M.

The Card in the Atlas

You found the library card inside the atlas, pressed flat on the page for Portugal. I had been looking for it too. I looked in the bread bin and under the rug and in the pocket of your green coat. I never thought of Portugal.

The card had your name on it in small grey letters. Someone had put a thumbprint of flour on the corner a long time ago. I think the card went to Portugal because it was tired of the bread bin. I would have gone too.

The Book kept the page: the card came home from Portugal with your name still on it.

SPECIMENS COLLECTED

Ink for Today 9:00

your own words

Heard someone practising the trumpet on my lunch break. It was colder than it looked.

Ironed a shirt for no reason on the way home. Nobody else noticed.



NIGHT BRAID · KEPT AT 10:00 P.M.

What the Fox Knew

The fox sat on the wall at dawn and did not run. You stopped on the step with your keys in your hand. Neither of you said anything. I was very quiet in your bag so I would not spoil it.

The Curse likes mornings that are all the same. This one was not. A fox looked at you and you looked back. That is two creatures refusing to be ordinary at the same time, and I saw it, and I wrote it down fast before it could turn back into a normal Tuesday.

The Book kept the page: the fox stayed on the wall, and so did you.

SPECIMENS COLLECTED

Ink for Today 9:00

your own words

Helped a stranger read a bus timetable while the kettle boiled. I nearly missed it.

Changed the bulb in the bathroom on the top deck of the bus. I didn't take a photo, on purpose.



18

SUNDAY · OCTOBER 2026

First Quarter · sky clear

Double Ninth Festival

IN THE ROOM


SERENITY


WICKER


PENNY


PROFESSOR


AMBROSE

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE GREAT HALL

Which preparation?

you chose · Supper with a Finished

Three preparations are underway. I can fit under one arm at a time.

Ambrose has laid a place at supper. Penny has chalk on her cuffs. Wicker has taken all the spoiled menus.

Where shall we go?

Supper with a Finished Man

you chose · The Academy must admit

Ambrose invites Dracula to supper.

“In here?” Penny asks.

“The soup's in here.”

He pulls back a chair. Dracula stops beside it.

“Your invitation is imprecise.”

“Sit down and we'll improve it.”

Ambrose never argues. He just puts food near you.

Serenity takes the place opposite him. Ambrose fills her bowl, yours,

his own. He leaves Dracula's empty.

“You presume I don't eat.”

“What would you like?”

Dracula looks at the soup.

“Nothing.”

Ambrose nods and passes the bread.

“I won't return to a finished life,” Dracula says.

Serenity sets down her spoon.

“You're staying by holding on to mine.”

He looks at her. She waits until he looks away.

Ambrose gets a sheet of paper from the recipe drawer. There's a butter mark in one corner.

I'd have found him a clean one. He didn't want a clean one.

Supper with a Finished Man

They write the other terms beneath the first. Dracula reads them all.

“And in exchange, I go back.”

“And let go,” Serenity says.

He puts a finger on the butter mark.

“This was a recipe.”

“Still is,” Ambrose says. “We're trying to get everyone out of the room alive.”

The Count signs. Permancer will add his name at the return.

Ambrose passes dessert around the table. Dracula's bowl stays empty.

I counted the spoons. There's one out for him anyway.

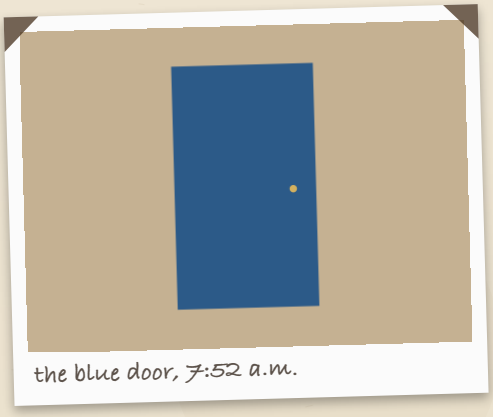
NIGHT BRAID · KEPT AT 10:00 P.M.

The Blue Door Changed Colour

The blue door was a different blue this morning. You noticed it on the way to the bus. Nobody on the street would say who did it. I think the door did it itself.

Doors are supposed to stay the colour they are painted. That is one of the Curse's rules. But this door had been blue for years, and it was bored, and it decided. I liked it very much for that. I want you to decide things like that too.

The Book kept the page: the blue door chose its own blue.



the blue door, 7:52 a.m.

SPECIMENS COLLECTED

Ink for Today	8:00
One-Sentence Souvenir	1:00

your own words

the blue door, 7:52 a.m.

Ate lunch on a bench facing the wrong way in the rain. My hands smelled of it all evening.



WEEK 4

Oct 22 – Oct 28



THE WEEK'S STRONGEST NIGHT

Bread That Would Not Rise

THE WEEK, DAY BY DAY

THU 22 The Wrong Castle

FRI 23 Bread That Would Not Rise

SAT 24 Your Brother Laughed Twice · a photograph

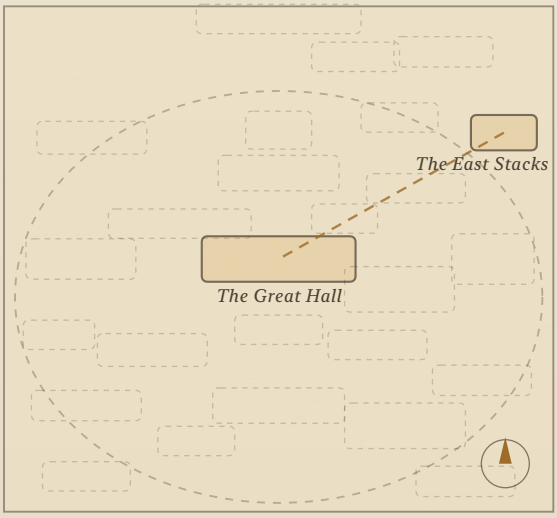
SUN 25 The Moth on Tuesday

MON 26 The Lamp Works

WED 28 A Future Tense · Return by Terms

4 NIGHTS BRAIDED

WHERE IT HAPPENED



22

THURSDAY · OCTOBER 2026

Waxing Gibbous · sky clear

IN THE ROOM


SERENITY


WICKER


PENNY


PROFESSOR

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE EAST STACKS

The Wrong Castle

you chose · The ballroom.

The East Stacks grow a tower overnight.

The bottom is library. The top has stolen a nursery window. Between them, a stair keeps asking for another floor.

A drawbridge hangs over the Quillquarium. The nibs underneath are furious. They've never agreed so completely.

I've read about a tower like this one. It wasn't supposed to get out.

Penny pins up a notice:

THE EAST STACKS ARE SEVERAL PLACES. PLEASE USE ONE AT A TIME.

Permancer ties ribbons to the banister. Wicker holds the source volume. Serenity studies her map.

“I'm coming,” she says.

“I was about to ask,” Permancer says.

“You're very slow.”

She folds the map into her repaired case. Wicker watches the clasp close. She catches him looking and goes ahead.

Permancer counts us at the door. He counts twice now.

Inside, the stair turns into a corridor. There are three ways through.

I put my ribbon in the door behind us so we can find it again.

The Wrong Castle

Dracula waits in the central hall. A fireplace blows snow into his coat. Above him, the borrowed nursery window is trying to find morning.

“This isn't my castle.”

“No,” Serenity says. “These are everybody else's rooms.”

A door opens onto a boat in a storm. Permancer wrestles it shut. Seawater soaks his shoes.

“You damaged my source,” Dracula says.

Permancer keeps both hands on the handle.

“We did.”

Wicker opens the book to his sentence. Under it, a second hand has written FOLLOW.

“I thought—”

Serenity waits.

He looks at the map case. At the bandage above it.

“I wanted to see what would happen.”

“You have.”

He lowers his eyes to the page.

The wall splits. Under the stone is a thin fold of paper.

That's paper. I'd know it in the dark. It's the same stuff I'm made of.

Serenity touches it. Her map pulls towards the gap.

“His way back.”

Permancer brings the bookmark near. Its ribbons reach towards the source, the gap, and Serenity.

Penny puts a card beside each.

SOURCE. INVITATION. LIVING CLAIM.

Dracula watches her write.

Serenity puts her own hand over the third card.

“That one's mine.”

Behind us, the sea knocks again.

Wind kept returning through the kept pages.



NIGHT BRAID · KEPT AT 10:00 P.M.

Bread That Would Not Rise

You baked bread that did not rise. It came out of the oven flat and heavy and you laughed at it. Then you ate two slices with too much butter standing up at the counter.

I have read a great many recipes. None of them say what to do when the bread refuses. You did the right thing. You ate the refusal. It tasted of butter and burnt edges, and you told me so, and I kept it.

The Book kept the page: the bread stayed flat, and you ate it anyway.

SPECIMENS COLLECTED

Ink for Today 9:00

your own words

Learned the name of the bakery cat after work. It rained again right after.



NIGHT BRAID · KEPT AT 10:00 P.M.

Your Brother Laughed Twice

You called your brother back instead of texting. He sounded tired. He laughed twice. I counted.

Texting is quick, and the Curse loves quick things because nothing sticks to them. A call is slow and scratchy and full of breathing. His laugh came down the line and sat in the room with you afterwards. I could still hear it in the kettle an hour later.

The Book kept the page: two laughs, counted and kept.



the river, going gold

SPECIMENS COLLECTED

Ink for Today	8:00
One-Sentence Souvenir	1:00

your own words
the river, going gold
Oiled the squeaky hinge
on the kitchen door late at
night. Shirley said it was
typical of me.



NIGHT BRAID · KEPT AT 10:00 P.M.

The Moth on Tuesday

A moth came in with the cold and settled on the calendar, right on Tuesday. You left it there. So Tuesday had a moth on it all week.

I asked the moth what it wanted with Tuesday. It did not answer, because it was a moth. But nothing bad happened on Tuesday. The bus was on time and the rain stopped at four. I think the moth was guarding it.

The Book kept the page: Tuesday had a moth, and Tuesday was fine.

SPECIMENS COLLECTED

Ink for Today 9:00
One-Sentence Souvenir 1:00

your own words

Wore odd socks all day at the library. I laughed out loud on my own.

Sat with Amanda while she waited for news by the river. The radio was playing something old.



NIGHT BRAID · KEPT AT 10:00 P.M.

The Lamp Works

You rewired the brass lamp in the hall. It took all afternoon and one small shock that made you swear. Then you flicked the switch and the hall turned gold.

The lamp had been dark for two years. It had forgotten it was a lamp. You reminded it with a screwdriver and a lot of patience. I stood very close to it all evening, because I like warm light to read by, and because I wanted it to know somebody noticed.

The Book kept the page: the lamp remembered it was a lamp.

SPECIMENS COLLECTED

Ink for Today 9:00

your own words

Tried a new route to work on the way home. It made me late, which was fine.



28

WEDNESDAY · OCTOBER 2026

Waning Gibbous

IN THE ROOM


SERENITY


WICKER


PENNY


PROFESSOR


AMBROSE

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE GREAT HALL

A Future Tense

you chose · Return by Terms

The stair has reached the supper tables.

Ambrose moves the salt out of its way. A paper moon hangs over the Great Hall, torn from a book that keeps calling for it.

On the wooden stand, *Dracula* tries to close.

I wedge myself beneath the cover. It presses down. I've held open heavier books than this.

Permancer reads the return list. This time he names everyone allowed through. Penny checks every ribbon from both sides.

Serenity stands by the final fold. The map case is open at her feet.

“He's coming.”

The paper moon goes dark.

Dracula descends the stair. He sees the open source, Serenity, and the invitation we've made.

Dracula stops on the last stair.

He has noticed.

Return by Terms

Ambrose brings the supper table to the threshold. It wobbles. He puts a folded menu under its short leg.

I'm still wedged under the Count's cover. Nobody's putting a menu under me.

Dracula reads his signature beside the butter mark.

Permancer signs the Academy's admission underneath.

“No promise of release,” the Count says.

“None.”

“No visit.”

“None.”

He looks at Serenity. She waits beside the open source.

“Poor terms.”

Ambrose puts a hand on the table to steady it.

“They're the ones you signed.”

He reads them twice. I hold. My corner's gone numb.

Dracula steps towards the threshold.

The claim is hers

At the edge of the source, Dracula turns to Serenity.

“You would send me back.”

She unfolds her map. The black line runs from him into the little kingdom she drew before any of this happened.

“What you changed in me is mine now.”

She puts a finger beneath the line.

“It doesn't belong to you.”

The ink lifts like a loose thread.

“It doesn't hold you here.”

She pulls it free.

His second shadow goes out. The open book drags at his coat.

I hold. A stitch parts in my spine.

Dracula looks into the source. For once, he doesn't know what to say before the page turns.

It turns anyway.

The stair breaks into words. The ballroom sheds its extra centuries. The drawbridge lifts out of the Quillquarium with a flock of nibs hanging from it.

The borrowed moon sails back between two covers.

Then the Great Hall is a hall again.

I wriggle out from under *Dracula*. My loose stitch catches. Penny frees it with her pencil.

Serenity listens.

Somewhere far away, a closed book turns a page.

She picks up her map case.

“Still there,” she says.

Ambrose pulls out a chair.

This time, it's for her.

Hour again. The theme insists.



WEEK 5

Oct 29 – Oct 30

THU FRI SAT SUN MON TUE WED

THE WEEK'S STRONGEST NIGHT

Nine Books, No Plan

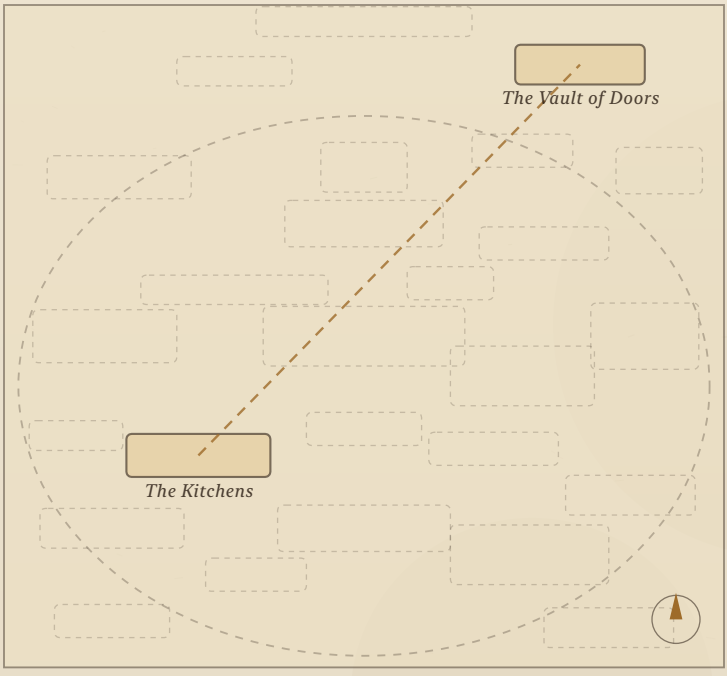
THE WEEK, DAY BY DAY

THU 29 The First Nightbound Morning

FRI 30 Nine Books, No Plan · Threshold Protocols

1 NIGHT BRAIDED

WHERE IT HAPPENED



29

THURSDAY · OCTOBER 2026

Waning Gibbous

IN THE ROOM


SERENITY


PROFESSOR


PENNY


AMBROSE

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE KITCHENS

The First Nightbound Morning

Morning finds Serenity in the Kitchens.

She's built the toast tower again. It has buttresses now.

Sunlight crosses her hands. She turns over a card. A moon. Another card. Another moon.

“Lazy,” she tells the deck.

Ambrose brings tea.

Permancer arrives with a phrase he's plainly been carrying all the way downstairs.

“Residual threshold sensitivity.”

Serenity looks up.

“Is that what the tea's called?”

He sits down.

“What would you call it?”

She looks at the pantry door. Behind it, too far away for anybody else, a page turns.

“Nightbound.”

Penny takes out a card. She waits until Serenity nods.

I make room for the word too.

Permancer puts a new notice on the table.

Name every traveller. Close the list. Check both sides of the door.

Below that:

No living anchors.

Serenity takes the pencil.

Ask me before you make a map of what I can hear.

Permancer reads it and leaves it where she wrote it.

Wicker appears in the doorway. His hair is wet; he's apparently tried to improve it with water and lost.

“May I?”

Serenity turns a card face down.

“Not today.”

He takes his hand off the frame.

“All right.”

She watches until he's gone. Then she moves a piece of toast that was holding up the tower.

The tower falls. She laughs, once, at the mess.

“Terrible engineering.”

Ambrose brings more toast.

I want you to have a morning like this one. Not this one. One of yours.



Amanda kept returning through the kept pages.

30

FRIDAY · OCTOBER 2026

Waning Gibbous · sky clear

IN THE ROOM


PROFESSOR


PENNY

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE VAULT OF DOORS

Threshold Protocols

The Academy opened a door. Someone came the other way.

Permancer has written these beside the Vault:

1. Name the source and why you are entering it.
2. Name every traveller allowed to return.
3. Close the invitation around those names.
4. Check the doorway from both sides.
5. Leave the people in the source their own lives. No experiments on them for the sake of a lesson.
6. No living anchors.
7. Ask before using what a changed person can do.
8. After the return, check what came back different.

Penny has pinned the old list beside the new one. The old one is complete. That is why she kept it.



Library kept returning through the kept pages.

NIGHT BRAID · KEPT AT 10:00 P.M.

Nine Books, No Plan

The library had a sale and you came home with nine books and no plan for them. You stacked them on the floor by the bed. The stack leaned. It is still leaning.

I was jealous for about a minute. Then I read their spines and decided they were friends. Nine books is nine doors. The Curse wants you to have one door and walk through it every day. You have ten now, counting me.

The Book kept the page: nine new doors, stacked and leaning.

SPECIMENS COLLECTED

Ink for Today 9:00

your own words

Wrote my brother a postcard on the back step. I don't know why it stayed with me.



WEDNESDAY 7 OCTOBER

"Tried a new route to work at the library. I told Amanda about it later."

Ink for Today

FRIDAY 9 OCTOBER

"Carried the heavy shopping up all four flights in the park by the war memorial. Shirley said it was typical of me." "Clear and sharp. My breath showed at the bus stop."

One-Sentence Souvenir · What the Sky Is Doing

SATURDAY 10 OCTOBER

"Burned the toast and ate it anyway before breakfast. My brother would have loved it." "Swapped recipes with the woman from 3B after work. I'm writing it down so I remember."

One-Sentence Souvenir · Ink for Today

SUNDAY 11 OCTOBER

"Clear and sharp. My breath showed at the bus stop." "Walked the dog from next door at Amanda's. Small thing. Still counts."

What the Sky Is Doing · One-Sentence Souvenir

TUESDAY 13 OCTOBER

"Wrote a list and then lost it at the library. It was nearly dark by then."

Ink for Today

THURSDAY 15 OCTOBER

"Found a coin with a hole through it by the river. I should do that more often."

Ink for Today

MONDAY 19 OCTOBER 🌓

"Gave the plant by the window a new pot at the diner. It took three tries." "Watched rain run down the bus window at the market. I kept thinking about it on the bus."

Ink for Today

THURSDAY 22 OCTOBER 🌓

"Bought flowers for no one in particular before breakfast. It was nearly dark by then."

Ink for Today





What This Month Was



Nothing in this month arranged itself into a story, and I am not going to invent one. It was a month. You were in it. That is already more than most things manage.

What I Noticed

Connections, absences, durations, and living Beliefs gathered from the month.

The Shape of the Month

21 journal pages
9 braids
7 souvenirs
2 sky notes

OCT 30

Returning Language

Certain words kept finding their way back: Clear, Wind, Rain, Cloud, Amanda, and Door. I treat them as motifs and atmosphere, not as a scorecard.

OCT 25

Library

Library only ever visits these pages in the morning: three times now, never at any other hour.

OCT 30

Serenity Brown

I keep finding Serenity Brown where I didn't put it: three kept Pages.

OCT 30

Serenity Brown

Serenity Brown has been in the margins for 23 days.

OCT 9

Penny Blackletter

Penny Blackletter has been in the margins for 23 days.

OCT 4

Wicker Eddies

Wicker Eddies has been in the margins for 28 days.

Kept, Not Bound

The month also held 5 quotes and 4 Bleed pages - kept in the archive, but not bound here.

What I Noticed

Connections that only show up when a whole month is held still at once.

OCT 7

You kept saying “work”

4 times, across 4 of your 17 written days. You may not have repeated it on purpose. A word returning this often earns a ribbon; I’m not deciding why.

Oct 7: “Tried a new route to work at the library. I told Amanda about it later.”
Oct 10: “Swapped recipes with the woman from 3B after work. I'm writing it down so I remember.”
Oct 23: “Learned the name of the bakery cat after work. It rained again right after.”

Book Memory Spine

The nightly Book of You pages, read as callbacks, refrains, and open questions.

OCT 30

Cover Story

Nine Books, No Plan

nine new doors, stacked and leaning

OCT 30

The Month's Refrain

Across the nightly braids, these motifs kept returning: door (2).

OCT 30

Pages That Kept Answering

Nine Books, No Plan: nine new doors, stacked and leaning
The Lamp Works: the lamp remembered it was a lamp
The Moth on Tuesday: Tuesday had a moth, and Tuesday was fine
Your Brother Laughed Twice: two laughs, counted and kept
Bread That Would Not Rise: the bread stayed flat, and you ate it anyway
The Blue Door Changed Colour: the blue door chose its own blue

The Complete Archive

Everything else the month kept: weather, anchors, enchantments, classes, questions, and every other margin. Nothing here was left out.

OCT 18

Ink for Today

Untangled a necklace for twenty minutes in the park by the war memorial. The light was doing something odd.

In Closing

So October 2026 closes. I've read all 39 pages back to you and to myself, and what could be kept has been kept. A month doesn't end so much as settle.

Carry this one out with you: Clear kept returning through the kept pages. I like when a true thing knocks twice.

“Hour and Weather” ran through the whole month. I've stopped asking whether you picked it.

The month is nailed down now. Come back and pry at it whenever you want; the bookmark will deny waiting. The next page is blank and already eavesdropping.

The Book



The Book of You (Wren) Chapter 10: October 2026

Bound by the Book itself, which read every page twice.

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